EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

A New Heaven and Earth, With No Night?

Given Monday 27 October 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 9:6-7

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 9 (Olam HaBa, The World to Come), Chapter 6 and the opening of Chapter 7

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 27 October 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Recap: Light and Fire

Essay 9 began with Saadia's arguments for Olam HaBa from logic, from the Torah and from rabbinic tradition. In **Chapter 5** last week he got into "the meat" of what Olam HaBa is, answering the first two of his questions:

- For Saadia, **Gan Eden and Gehinnom are synonymous with Olam HaBa**. Reward in Olam HaBa is Gan Eden; punishment in Olam HaBa is Gehinnom.
- Both come from **one entity, like the sun**. The righteous receive its **light**; the wicked receive its **heat and fire**. Somehow Hashem makes it that the tzaddikim get only the light and the resha'im only the heat.

"That's a very difficult concept to accept, and the Rambam certainly wouldn't have accepted something like this," as discussed in the Tuesday shiur. Many of Saadia's views in this essay are "quite novel and quite radical and certainly not the accepted view. But we're learning Saadia, and let's see his view."

Chapter 6, Question 3: Where Will Olam HaBa Be?

Having explained the nature of reward and punishment, Saadia turns to the third question: **the place** of those rewarded and those punished. Since in Olam HaBa people are **bodies with souls**, they need a place to be, something to surround them. Hashem will **create** such a place and settle them in it.

For the **Rambam**, the Rabbi noted, the question never begins. Why would you need a location when there is no body? In Olam HaBa there is only the soul, **נהנים מזיו השכינה**. But for Saadia, and for other Rishonim who hold there will be a body, it is a real question.

The proof: a new heaven and earth

Saadia says the Prophets already speak of this new universe, though they call it **"heaven and earth"** to bring it closer to our understanding, because heaven and earth are all we can see.

כי כאשר השמים החדשים והארץ החדשה אשר אני עשה עמדים לפני נאם ה' כן יעמד זרעכם ושמכם (Yeshayahu 66:22)

For just as the new heavens and the new earth that I am making will endure before Me, says Hashem, so will your descendants and your name endure.

This chapter is the **haftarah of Shabbat Bereishit**, read a couple of weeks before. For Saadia, the "new heavens and new earth" is **a new universe**, where the righteous and the wicked will both dwell.

Why not this world?

Saadia asks: why does Hashem need to make a new universe at all? When the 6,000 years end, why not simply begin Olam HaBa here?

His answer: **this earth was made for nourishment and commerce.** That is why it has fields and gardens for planting, rivers and streams to water people, animals and trees, seas and channels for rain and flow, deserts where animals graze, and roads for travel. We need all of this because we must constantly feed ourselves and constantly buy and trade.

But in Olam HaBa there is **neither food nor commerce**. The Gemara is clear: **העולם הבא אין בו לא אכילה ולא שתיה**. As Saadia explained last week, people there will be sustained by light, as Moshe Rabbeinu was during his three periods of forty days and forty nights. So there is no need for fields, plants, rivers or mountains. All people need is **a dwelling that surrounds them**, which Hashem will create as He wishes.

The Rabbi's two comments

1. What about the rest of the universe? In Saadia's time, 1,100 years ago, nobody knew anything beyond the earth, apart from the stars and perhaps some planets. Saadia, as the class saw in an earlier essay, held a **geocentric** view: the earth is in the middle and the stars revolve around us. Now we know how vast the universe is. When the 6,000 years end, is the new world just a new planet Earth? What happens to the rest of the universe? "I can accept your planet Earth. But the entire universe, what's going to happen to that? Who knows? I don't know what Saadia would say to that. He didn't know about it, so he didn't discuss it."

2. Is the world only for food? "I find it difficult to accept that the whole reason why we have everything around us is just for food and possessions. Is there not intrinsic value to the earth around us, to the trees around us, for our eyes to benefit and to enjoy these things?" Hashem created the world for His glory:

כל הנקרא בשמי ולכבודי בראתיו יצרתיו אף עשיתיו (Yeshayahu 43:7)

Everyone called by My name, whom I created for My glory, formed and made.

There are many pesukim in Tehillim and statements of Chazal along the same lines: the world declares Hashem's wonders, and when we look at nature we see His beauty. "Saadia has reduced all of that just to food. I find that difficult as well."

The verse is not conclusive: Ibn Ezra and Radak

The Rabbi then showed that the pasuk Saadia relies on is "absolutely not conclusive."

The **Ibn Ezra** (read in English translation) says the right explanation is that "heavens" means the atmosphere over the earth. God will create a new, good atmosphere; people will be healthy and enjoy long life; and He will increase the earth's fertility, as though it were new. "Those who refer this passage to the future life are wrong, for it cannot agree with the context of the chapter," since the surrounding pesukim speak about eating and drinking, and in the future life there is neither, as our sages taught. For the Ibn Ezra this refers to the days of Mashiach or techiyat hametim, not to a new world.

The **Radak** says similarly: the new heavens and earth "stand in their newness" and do not wear out. They are the same today as on the day they were created, and so they will remain. Only what grows on the earth wears out. As Shlomo said:

דור הלך ודור בא והארץ לעולם עמדת (Kohelet 1:4)

A generation goes and a generation comes, but the earth stands forever.

So both reject Saadia's reading. The Ibn Ezra says the context cannot support it; the Radak says the earth will never end. The Rambam would have to interpret the same way, since for him there is no new place.

Two chapters, two readings

Saadia has another problem, "which is really not comfortable for him." There are **two** pesukim about a new heaven and earth. Besides Chapter 66, there is Chapter 65:

כי הנני בורא שמים חדשים וארץ חדשה... כי הנני בורא את ירושלם גילה ועמה משוש (Yeshayahu 65:17-18)

For I am creating new heavens and a new earth... for I am creating Jerusalem as a joy and her people as a delight.

This cannot be Olam HaBa, because it speaks of Yerushalayim, which belongs to the time of Mashiach and techiyat hametim. So Saadia is forced to say that **Chapter 65 is a metaphor**: Hashem renews the people's joy "as if" He created a new world. "We're not creating a new Jerusalem." It means a new environment of happiness and peace instead of war, as if it were a new creation, "just like the Ibn Ezra and Radak say." But **Chapter 66**, he says, is literal: a real new place that Hashem will create, after He wipes out the present earth and heavens.

His proof that the present world will end:

לפנים הארץ יסדת ומעשה ידיך שמים. המה יאבדו ואתה תעמד... ושנותיך לא יתמו. בני עבדיך ישכונו (Tehillim 102:26-29)

Of old You founded the earth, and the heavens are the work of Your hands. They will perish, but You will endure... and Your years will not end. The children of Your servants will dwell.

If heaven and earth perish and yet the children of Hashem's servants "will dwell," there must be another place for them to dwell in.

Saadia adds a point about **air**, which the Rabbi said he did not fully understand: the air we breathe draws from our bodies what has to be replaced by food. Since in Olam HaBa people will not need food, there must be a new kind of air there too.

"Saadia is really pushed here, I feel." And this pasuk too is not conclusive. The **Ibn Ezra** notes that those who say heaven and earth will perish must explain other pesukim, such as **אם ימשו החקים האלה** in Yirmiyahu, and in Tehillim:

ויעמידם לעד לעולם חק נתן ולא יעבור (Tehillim 148:6)

He established them forever and ever; He set a law that will not pass.

We say this every morning in Pesukei deZimra. He brings **Rabbi Yehudah ben David**, the first grammarian in the West, who explained that **the general things endure forever and the particulars perish**. "They will perish" means the details, "the exact science," will change. The earth itself will not be destroyed. The Rambam would also read it like that.

The Rambam: the world need not end

For the Rambam there is no new earth, because Olam HaBa is the soul alone. There is a Gemara in **Sanhedrin** that this world lasts 6,000 years, but the Rabbi said he thinks it is very clear in the **Moreh Nevuchim** that the Rambam did not treat it as authoritative. The Rambam did not, at least explicitly, accept that this world will end. "And you think about it, why not?" If Olam HaBa is souls with God, why does the earth need to end? Humans could live for thousands, even millions, of years. Somewhere in that time would come Mashiach and techiyat hametim, "a very specific time. But in the grand scheme of things, why do we need the earth to come to an end?" God created humans to work and build their Olam HaBa, "so why shouldn't He do that for thousands of years, millions of years or for eternity even?"

"We're discussing things which are beyond our knowledge and everyone's given a view, but that's the best we can do."

Chapter 6, Question 4: Is There Time in Olam HaBa?

"This is quite simple and short."

כי זמן כולו אור בלי חושך

Its time is all light without darkness.

There will not be two watches, night and day, one after the other. Why did Hashem create night and day in this world, through the movement of the sun?

- **The day**, to busy ourselves with our livelihood and our journeys.
- **The night**, for rest, quiet, sleep and solitude.

In Olam HaBa there is no work and no travel, so there is certainly no need for night and day. "It's just 24-hour day."

Likewise there will be **no months and years**. We need those in this world for accounts and contracts: buying and renting a house, knowing when to plant, which year the field lies fallow. In Olam HaBa, with no work and no commitments, there is no need for any of it.

A little time for avodah

But Saadia adds that **a small part of time will remain**, for the **service of Hashem**. This is another "shocking thing" that will come later: Saadia holds there is some kind of avodat Hashem in Olam HaBa. He reads the pasuk about the future, **והיה מדי חדש בחדשו ומדי שבת בשבתו** (Yeshayahu 66:23), "from new moon to new moon and from Shabbat to Shabbat," as service on Rosh Chodesh and Shabbat. So although there is no time, there is a small element of time, for the moments of serving Hashem. The class will discuss it when they get there.

"The more we're learning, the more difficult it's getting"

"Isn't there some value to having some kind of change of scenery?" The clocks had just changed and winter had begun. "People don't like the winter. I find the winter difficult. It's dark and it's cold. But at the end of the day, it's nice to have a night and a day and to have a change of scenery."

If Olam HaBa is purely spiritual, the Rabbi said, all of this is understandable: no body, no place, no time, just eternity. But Saadia places us in a new universe, a new earth, and then says it is always daytime, with none of the plants we have here. "What kind of universe is this going to be? But that's what he says."

Summary of Chapter 6

Question	Saadia's answer
1 and 2: reward and punishment	One substance, like the sun: light for the righteous, fire for the wicked; Gan Eden and Gehinnom are Olam HaBa
3: place	A **brand new** place, since this earth exists for food and commerce; Yeshayahu 66 is literal, Yeshayahu 65 is a metaphor for Messianic times
4: time	**All day, no night**, no months or years, only a small element of time for avodat Hashem

---

Chapter 7, Questions 5 and 6: Why Must Reward and Punishment Be Eternal?

Chapter 7 deals with **the eternity of the reward of the righteous and the punishment of the wicked**: are Gan Eden and Gehinnom forever, and if so, why must they be? Saadia says he will explain it rationally.

Reward: the greatest incentive

When Hashem obligated people to serve Him, He had to stir their desire with **the greatest incentive possible**. If He had attracted them with something small and they did not serve Him, someone could say: had You offered me more, I would have served You. "It's your fault, God."

אם שם זמן גמול הצדיקים אלף שנה...

Had the reward of the righteous been set at a thousand years...

A person could say he did not serve Hashem because it was only a thousand years. The same with two thousand or three thousand: "Yeah, but I've got 100 years now, definitely. Let me enjoy the 100 years now and I'll worry about the 3,000 years later. Had you told me that this is for 10,000 years, I would have changed my mind." **Anything with a limit can be rationalised away.** But when the reward is without end, no claim remains. So reward must be eternal.

Punishment: the greatest fear

The natural follow-up question came from the participants: why would punishment be eternal? Flora said that was exactly her question. Another participant (Richard) suggested the same answer as Saadia: it is a sanction, so that people want to avoid it. He added that since one can atone for anything in one's lifetime, including sins that carry karet, an eternal punishment is also an incentive to do teshuvah while alive. "There's nothing you can't atone for," the Rabbi agreed.

Saadia raises the objection himself. Eternal reward is a benefit and a kindness. But **perpetual suffering in fire** seems to abandon mercy and to be cruel, which does not fit the ways of the Creator.

His answer mirrors the first:

כן התחייב להפחידם הפחד שאין גדול ממנו

So too He had to frighten them with the greatest fear there is.

If Hashem had threatened a thousand years of punishment, someone could say: had You made it two thousand, I would have kept away from sin. If two thousand, then: had You made it tens of thousands. So Hashem made the suffering **without end**, the greatest fear, so that no one is left with that claim.

"Perhaps it is only a threat"

Saadia also anticipates the next thought. Perhaps Hashem only **says** the punishment is eternal, to frighten us, and in reality it will be much shorter? The Rabbi noted there is a "catch 22": if we could think that at the back of our heads, the threat would lose its force and the argument would return.

Saadia answers: once Hashem has warned with the complete fear and they did not listen, **it would not be right for Him to go back on His word**. Hashem is the God of truth, so He must keep His word, and the suffering must continue. "It's your own fault." Saadia even turns it on its head: making the fear so great is itself **a kindness**, because it gives us the greatest incentive to do the Torah and mitzvot.

Saadia compares it to other things Hashem created wisely that turn harmful through a person's own misconduct. If you do not look after your health, you suffer, and cannot blame anyone afterwards. So too with spiritual health.

The Rabbi's discomfort

"Leaving aside obvious discomfort, I find it very difficult to accept that HaKadosh Baruch Hu would punish a person eternally in burning fire." He asked the class to think of the pain of a burn, and of the atrocities of **the 7th of October**, which we have not stopped talking about. "That's a few minutes. Just think of that for a month, for a day, for even an hour. How terrible that pain is for one hour." To think it is eternal "is very scary. If it's true, it's very scary."

For the **Rambam**, there is no such concept. There may be some punishment, perhaps a few months in Gehinnom as a kind of purging, and perhaps an eternal sense of having missed out, but no eternal damnation.

Flora's objection

Flora said she understood the argument for reward, but not for punishment: even one minute of burning would frighten her, so how could anyone say a limited time was not enough? The Rabbi answered that the logic is "I've got 100 years of a good life now; I'll worry about it later." He agreed the argument is "quite weak to be honest" from the beginning, but said the question works equally on the reward: "You give me a reward for 10,000 years, it's not enough?" If you accept it for the good, you can accept it for the bad.

The Rambam: consequences, not incentives

For the Rambam the whole conversation is "a non-starter." Hashem did not give us mitzvot to earn reward. He gave them because that is what is best for our nature and our development. Being a better person naturally leads to a better afterlife. Saadia's model, in which Hashem wants us to do mitzvot and therefore offers a very long reward to make sure we do them, the Rambam would not accept.

Someone asked: doesn't one of the **Thirteen Principles** speak of reward and punishment? The Rabbi answered, as he has said many times, that "reward and punishment" are Christian terms. The Rambam's word is **גמול**, consequence. One of the Thirteen Principles is that our actions have consequences, the foundation of the Torah, "but not in a sense of you do mitzvot, you get reward." You do the mitzvot because they are best for you as a human being, and the natural consequence is goodness in Olam HaBa: **למען ייטב לך**. So for the Rambam it is eternal simply "because that's the identity you've created for yourself, full stop."

More questions

Who keeps the record of eight billion people? HaKadosh Baruch Hu, "100%. That's definite according to everyone, that's fundamental." He does so because He cares for each of us to become the best version of ourselves. From a human perspective it sounds crazy: eight billion diaries, eight billion computers. But:

כי לא מחשבותי מחשבותיכם (Yeshayahu 55:8)

For My thoughts are not your thoughts.

"God's knowledge is a different kind of knowledge, and I can't explain to you because I've got no idea what it is, but it's certainly not our knowledge."

Is everything sealed at death? Richard asked whether, for Saadia, death fixes a person's state with no further elevation. "Absolutely not," there is no elevation, because Saadia refuted **gilgul** at length. "You die, that's it." What Saadia does not explain anywhere is what happens between death and the end of the 6,000 years. The **Ramban** understands Gan Eden and Gehinnom as a kind of waiting room. But everyone agrees that, unless you believe in reincarnation, death ends the chance to change. "We've got our chance in this world, and that's it." The Ramban does believe in gilgul, and reads the whole book of Iyov in that light.

Looking Ahead

Saadia will next bring pesukim to show that reward and punishment are eternal. "You may be thinking to yourself, of course everyone believes reward and punishment is eternal. You'll be

shocked to learn" that some views hold Gehinnom is **not** eternal, including views in the Gemara in Rosh Hashanah. Next week: is the eternity of reward and punishment the accepted view, from the Gemara down to later authorities?

The Tuesday shiur the next night would turn to the Rambam's view of Mashiach and techiyat hametim within his framework of Olam HaBa. And at the very end, a request from a participant: "Try to make it less depressing." "I'll try."

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/xfnvo7-gDfw · More shiurim: rabbikada.com